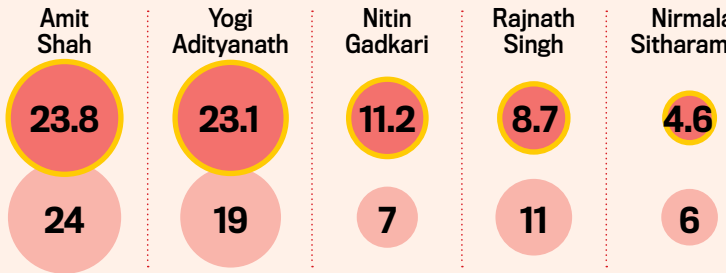


ANI

Q. WHO IS BEST SUITED TO SUCCEED MODI AS THE BJP's PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE?



MOTN Jan. 2022 MOTN Aug. 2021
Rest: DK/ CS and others; all figure in per cent

FOR THE FIRST TIME, THE MOTN POLL SHOWS A **DEAD HEAT BETWEEN AMIT SHAH AND YOGI ADITYANATH** AS BJP'S PM CANDIDATE AFTER MODI

They could take credit for continuing to have public support in the face of unprecedented crises, unlike the Manmohan Singh government whose popularity wilted away within two years of the UPA government's second term. Yet the growing economic discontent, especially over inflation and unemployment, spells trouble for Modi and his party. The BJP's election strategy of polarisation, hyper-nationalism and individual welfarism may not be enough to see them through in 2024.

This is because while beneficiaries laud Modi for his many welfare schemes, they still want secure employment and growth in income rather than live on government doles. The MOTN survey reflects the perception that the government's economic policies have largely benefited big business. There are other related strands in the survey that Modi and his team should worry about. For one, the trepidation among people to speak out openly for fear of retribution. Then, there is the concern that democracy and its institutions are being undermined. Minorities remain sceptical about communal harmony. In the remaining years of his second term, the prime minister must take steps to address the disquiet by initiating a dialogue for a grand political reconciliation.

Modi's biggest challenge is to deliver the economic growth that could result in more jobs and prevent runaway inflation. There is concern that if there is a setback for the BJP in the UP assembly poll, the prime minister may turn more circumspect in implementing the reforms he unleashed in his second term. The recension of the farm laws is seen as one such example of him yielding to political pressures. Those who work closely with Modi, however, dismiss such misgivings and insist that the prime minister will vigorously pursue all reforms, including the massive privatisation push he has initiated. The government is confident that Omicron will not damage the economy in the way that the first wave did.

Moreover, his advisors believe that his government's recent economic stimulus and reforms, in addition to the other measures on the anvil, will ensure rapid economic development and address unemployment concerns. Dr P.K. Mishra, principal secretary to the PM, tells INDIA TODAY, "We have taken a balanced, cohesive approach with a short-, medium- and long-term perspective for growth. While both unemployment and inflation remain a challenge, we are confident we will be able to tackle them. The reform process will not slow down. The prime minister wants total change in the current systems and processes. He is convinced that India needs rapid economic growth to become a developed country by 2047." Having worked with the PM in various capacities for over two decades, Mishra goes on to add, "The prime minister now moves with a great deal of confidence and remains focused on the pace of change—he wants things to be done more quickly and monitors all issues closely." It's a faith the MOTN respondents also seem to place in the PM's ability to pull the country through the crisis and take it to greater heights. They are still banking on Modi to not let India down. ■